

Tutorials Design Thinking Methods

This framework helps teams move from understanding a problem to building and validating a real solution.

The process is iterative, not linear.

Teams may move back and forth between phases (especially between prototyping, testing, and redefining the problem).

Phase	Methods	What you do	Value Proposition
1. Explore the problem	AEIOU, Problem Definition	Observe the situation and understand the context	Field of opportunity identified
2. Understand the user	Persona, Empathy Map, Journey	Build a deep understanding of users and their needs	Initial assumptions about user desirability (needs, pains, gains)
3. Define the problem & value	Critical Issues, Problem Statement, HMW, Value Proposition Canvas	Identify key challenges and define how you want to create value	Clear value hypothesis — desirability defined, viability questions raised (VPC + BMC)
4. Generate ideas	Brainwriting, Walt Disney	Create a wide range of ideas	Ideas aligned with user value, first feasibility check
5. Prototype & Test	Prototyping, User Testing	Make ideas tangible and learn from feedback	Test desirability with users; technical feasibility tested
6. Build MVP	MoSCoW, MVP thinking	Create a minimal working solution with core value	Validate value in real context — including early viability signals (cost, channels)
7. Business & Value	Value Proposition, BMC	Turn your validated solution into a sustainable business	Refine value proposition into a viable, scalable business model

The "Value Proposition" column tracks how three lenses develop across phases: desirability (do users want it?), feasibility (can we build it?) and viability (does it sustain a business?). All three are addressed throughout the process, not only at the end.

Problem Definition

The Problem Definition Tool helps you clarify your priorities by focusing on key critical issues. It is beneficial to use this tool because it is a simple yet structured framework that helps to open a problem up so that you can view it from different perspectives to find innovative solutions. It encourages you to think clearly about what exactly you are working on.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o4dddmOpQ5s>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1-QbLT6E9Zc>

AEIOU

AEIOU (Activities, Environment, Interactions, Objects, Users) is an observation tool which helps to categorize and interpret observations collected during user research field studies and usability testing. AEIOU is useful because it helps think through a scenario or problem from a variety of perspectives.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Uvvd6pcNX84>

<https://youtu.be/kkhog6Hq12M>

Persona

A persona is a profile that represents a particular group of people, a market segment, or any other stakeholder group. A persona is not a stereotype, rather it's an archetype based on research. Even though personas are fictional, they help make groups of people with similar needs more understandable.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GNvLpfXCge8>

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SzkU_RFhKC8

<https://youtu.be/DvV7ZcRVQ4g>

Empathy Map

An empathy map is a collaborative tool teams can use to gain a deeper insight into their customers. It is a simple, easy-to-digest visual that captures knowledge about a user's behaviors and attitudes. Therefore, it is an extremely useful tool to help teams better understand their users.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QwF9a56WFWA>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Qz7EwkprvF>

Customer Journey Canvas

The Customer Journey is a tool to help you get insight into, track, and discuss how a customer experiences a problem you are trying to solve. How does this problem or opportunity show up in their lives? How do they experience it? How do they interact with you?

<http://www.designabetterbusiness.tools/tools/customer-journey-canvas>

Critical Issues

Critical issues help prioritize the pains and gains of the customer empathy map(s). Select from the pains and gains those issues that are particularly important for your customers. That's it :-)

Problem Statement

A problem statement identifies the gap between the current state (i.e. the problem) and the desired state (i.e. the goal) of a process or product. Based on what you've found out before, the final and essential step of this phase is to define a clear problem statement with you team. It will guide the entire design, ideate, and prototype process from here on out, giving you a fixed goal to focus on and helping to keep the user in mind at all times.

"Our (WHO) has the problem (WHAT), when (WHERE). Our solution should deliver (WHY)."

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cZLgh5JF_a8

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kT0ZqwdPYRM>

How Might We

The identified critical issues can be transferred into HMW questions. By asking questions, brainstorming sessions on possible solutions can be more fruitful.

The How Might We Method is a (proven) design thinking activity which has participants simply rephrase known challenges as a question beginning with “How Might We”.

A How might we (HMW) question can generate lots of creative ideas. Here are some examples of How might we questions:

- How might we ensure more people pay their taxes before the deadline?
- How might we help employees stay productive and healthy when working from home?
- How might we make customers feel that their information is safe and secure when creating an account?

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YwkrpBeuJms>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XUW78qyyObE>

Value Proposition Canvas

When it comes time to really understand your customers, including their jobs-to-be-done, pains, and gains, as well as your offer to them, the Value Proposition Canvas, developed by Alex Osterwalder at Strategyzer AG, is one of the best tools available to help you in this regard.

<http://www.designabetterbusiness.tools/tools/customer-journey-canvas>

Business Model Canvas

The Business Model Canvas can be used as a cross-phase tool — start it in Phase 3 alongside the Value Proposition Canvas and gradually fill in the remaining fields as the project progresses through the later phases.

The business model canvas is a great tool to help you understand a business model in a straightforward, structured way. Using this canvas will lead to insights about the customers you serve, what value propositions are offered through what channels, and how your company makes money. You can use the business model canvas to understand your own business model or that of a competitor! The Business Model Canvas was created by Alexander Osterwalder, of Strategyzer.

<http://www.designabetterbusiness.tools/tools/business-model-canvas>

6-3-5 Brainwriting

6-3-5 Brainwriting is a group-structured brainstorming technique aimed at aiding innovation processes by stimulating creativity.

In brief, it consists of 6 participants supervised by a moderator who are required to write down 3 ideas on a specific worksheet within 5 minutes; this is also the etymology of the methodology's name. The outcome after 6 rounds, during which participants swap their worksheets passing them on to the team member sitting at their right, is 108 ideas generated in 30 minutes. The technique is applied in various sectors but mainly in business, marketing, design, and writing, as well as everyday real life situations.

Number of participants, ideas and rounds can certainly be different.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yg9Svx9zkzw>

Walt Disney Method

The method is a tool for creative thinking to both: individuals and groups. The objective is to develop unexpected but feasible solutions for a given problem. The concept is inspired by the famous Walt Disney who used to step in different roles when developing new ideas. It was formally defined by Robert B. Dilts in the early 90's. The special power of the method is the combination of dreaming with a sense for reality.

It all starts with a tangible, precise question. Once the task is clear the participants work on the subject from three different perspectives consecutively: dreamer, realist and questioner. The perspectives represent different personalities and styles of thinking. The unique feature of the method is to give enough separate space for all perspectives.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FyOBk0filqs&t=32s>

Prototyping

A prototype is an early, simplified version of a product or feature used to explore ideas and gather feedback before investing in full development. Prototypes can range from low-fidelity paper sketches and storyboards to interactive digital mockups. The aim is to make ideas tangible and to learn quickly and cheaply what works and what does not.

User Testing

User testing means putting your prototype in front of real users and observing how they interact with it. The goal is not to prove that your idea works, but to discover what does not — so you can iterate. Even a small number of test users (typically 5–7) reveals the most important usability issues. Prepare clear test tasks, observe more than you explain, and capture both what users do and what they say.

MoSCoW

MoSCoW is a prioritization technique used to reach a shared understanding with stakeholders about the importance of each requirement. The acronym stands for Must have, Should have, Could have, and Won't have (this time). It helps teams focus on what is essential for an MVP, separates true necessities from nice-to-haves, and makes scope discussions more concrete.

MVP Thinking

A Minimum Viable Product (MVP) is the version of a new product with just enough features to deliver core value to early users — and to generate validated learning for future development. MVP thinking means resisting the urge to build everything at once: you ship the smallest meaningful version, observe real-world use, and iterate based on evidence rather than assumptions.